

leveraging AI to automate routine processes, provide analytical insights for better decision-making and create new opportunities for skilled labour. The objective is to blend AI's capabilities with the existing workforce.

The question now is how soon, how effective, how expensive and, finally, how safe will this technology be? AI can be a force for good if private entities and governments come together with a vision to democratise data and further global development and well-being. This partnership could also make available a vast amount of government data that could help make better policy decisions. But data and AI, while powerful, also happen to open up several concerns around privacy, governance and ethics. It is, therefore, imperative to lay out a strong governance foundation. There are at least four important ways to achieve that:

- **Facilitate the growth of AI:** The government can play a key role in the growth of AI in India by creating a conducive environment for DeepTech entrepreneurs and encouraging R&D investments in the emerging fields of AI/ quantum computing. India should consider co-investing Rs 5,000 crore in AI companies alongside established venture capital/private equity firms.

- **Leverage AI for our government use-cases:** The government is the biggest beneficiary of AI technologies, especially in areas like agri-tech, health-tech, taxation and defence. The state should commit to an annual spend of Rs 5,000 crore on AI use-cases that Indian startups can bid for and solve for the government of India.

- **Govern the rise of AI:** There are privacy, accuracy, explainability and fairness-related concerns. Introducing comprehensive data protection and responsible AI policies and investing in privacy-preserving AI technologies will help in governing its rise. Nasscom's 'Responsible AI Resource Kit' (indiaai.gov.in) is a great first step.

- **Prepare the country for the disruptions caused due to AI:** In their book *Bridgital Nation*, N. Chandrasekaran and Roopa Purushothaman estimate that India will add 91 million people to its workforce from 2020-30. AI adoption will lead to automation and change in 'tasks' within various industries. Committing to training at least 50 million citizens in digital skills over the next five years is thus imperative.

The questions surrounding AI, from its timeline of impact to its effectiveness and safety, may persist, but the imperative remains clear: a strategic and inclusive approach to AI development can unlock unprecedented opportunities for India's development. ■